

Diary Entry of Lt. Aime Ernest Motsch (also known as Lieutenant X) on the Siege of Manila during the War in the Philippines in 1898

The Siege of Manila Diary Entry of Lieutenant Aime Ernest Motsch is part of his diary entries about the War in the Philippines in the 1898 which were translated from French to English by Marietta Enriquez-de la Haye Jouselin. 21 years old at that time, Lt. Motsch (who was also known by his pseudonym of “Lieutenant X”), was the officer in charge of the only French battleship docked in the Manila Bay, the *Bruix*, alongside with the other European empires who were “observing” the suspenseful turn of events of the wars amongst the Spaniards, Americans and Filipinos. His diary dating from April 28 to August 31, 1898, fleshed out the specifics of the battles, its aftermath and the general sentiments of the political actors involved in the war theater that was the Spanish-American War. Aside from the diary entries providing firsthand account and thus, can be used to corroborate other primary sources pertaining to the Siege of Manila, for instance, perhaps the strength of Lt. X account as a historical document draws from its “spontaneity” and “unofficial nature” as what Jouselin noted “ [the entries] reveal the man behind the military officer, watching the battle in progress, and freely expressing his reactions and opinions.” However, one should also take a grain of salt when reading and using Lt. X entries as there are evidences of lower treatment towards the natives can be gleaned (ie: use of the term “insurgent” instead of “revolution” in labelling the Filipino faction in the war).

SIEGE OF MANILA

Sunday, 29 May

The blockade of Manila is now a month old.

The weather will worsen. The Americans have not planted their strategy against the city. They are waiting for the ground troops to arrive from San Francisco. Meanwhile, the insurgents have taken up arms, each day coming closer to Manila, where the Spaniards have allowed themselves to be hemmed in. There will be enough time for action when the Americans disembark.

In the bay, we see the English who seem to be well positioned beside Admiral Dewey’s squadron, the Germans giving the impression that they have a strategy, the Japanese who come and go, and the French who wait, observing, fully aware that their presence will not influence the coming events.

Each fleet is preoccupied with protecting its nationals. On Thursday morning the French delegates came on board, led by the consul and a French engineer who works at the *Compagnie Generale des Tabacs*. We discussed the arrangements: the engineer can provide us with a company ship for transporting the maximum number of men, along with their valuable possessions and provisions, when the attack is confirmed. We think that this will happen anytime now. The ship will therefore come alongside and be protected by our cannons. There is room for a large number of persons. France is protecting the Greeks, the Rumanians, the Valaques, and all her former Levantine clientele – without continuing the Turks. Many women of easy virtue are

from the Levant. They pretend to be Moldo- Valaques, but whether they are or not, they also need our protection. The fear of bombing poses a great number of social problems.

Essentially, the insurgents are at the moment the masters of the situation. It is their word which prevails on land. They are feared by the Spaniards and have given their support to the Americans. Can the Spaniards' travail be taken seriously? Everything they do could be merely to give the impression that they alone have prepared defensive measures.

Monday, May 30

This morning, at 6 o'clock, I went on shore with a comrade. We visited the markets of Binondo and San Miguel. There is an enormous crowd of Tagals and Chinese. Baskets full of fish and delicious fruits are everywhere. The smell of the Chinese overpowers even that of the sea. There is an abundance of lively colors and movements. The looks directed at us are either sympathetic or indifferent, but not at all hostile. The streets are swarming with people discussing among themselves, keeping pace with the tempo on the streets without stopping for a single moment to reflect on the present catastrophe before them.

-And yet, someone said to us an hour later, the fighting began this morning, very early, at Las Piñas, at the very threshold of Manila. The insurgents are putting less and less distance between themselves and the Spaniards with each passing moment. Before long, the two will be at each other's throats.

-What exactly do the insurgents want?

-The other day there was an important meeting between the Philippine chiefs and the high officials in Manila, in which Aguinaldo was supposed to have been the spokesman for his side. He simply stated that his men were well armed, a fact the Spaniards are quite aware of since they themselves had armed the Tagals a month ago. They seemed pleased with themselves that the insurgents of a year ago are now on their side against the Americans. In spite of everything, Aguinaldo is alleged to have offered his assistance, provided that three conditions be followed: 1) the expulsion of all religious orders; 2) the transfer of all ecclesiastical goods, furniture, and buildings for the civil use of the Filipinos; 3) absolute autonomy. This is what is being rumored around, but there is no truth to it. Aguinaldo is in Cavite, brought there from Hongkong by the Americans. In the city, the foreigners are getting worried. This is an absurd situation which cannot go on any longer. Tomorrow the ships which have been chartered will leave the river. The trunks are fast and secure and the final pieces of baggage are being put on board.

-And what is the news from Europe?

-The opinions one hears in the city are that the European powers will provide help. We are confident of Germany. I have received a report from a Hongkong correspondent that a naval battle can be expected. Details of the expected American defeat are not yet known, and Europe is preparing to intervene at the earliest opportunity.

Letter of Henry Thompson to his parents dated 8 February 1899, published in *Inside the Fighting First: Papers of a Nebraska Private in the Philippine War*, edited by Thomas Solevad Nielsen, (Nebraska: Lur Publications, Danish Immigrant Archive, Dana College, 2001), 98-99.

Thomas Nielsen's "Inside the Fighting First: Papers of a Nebraska Private in the Philippine War" contains Private Henry O. Thompson's letters and diary entries during the course of the Philippine-American War. After Thompson's death, his family donated the materials to the Danish Immigrant Archive at Dana College, Nebraska. Thomas Nielsen, editor from the archive, work on the materials and submit the edited version to the Lur Publications. Private Thompson left his farming life to volunteer for the Pacific Battle as part of the Co K, 1st Regiment Nebraska Volunteers. Henry Thompson's letters were unedited resulting in the presence of errors. Although there were grammatical errors, the unedited version reflected more the voice of the writer. Nielsen attributed the grammatical and spelling errors to Private Thompson's shift from the Danish to the English language. Private Thompson was born to Danish immigrant parents. In one of the letters addressed to his parents, Private Thompson's narrated their company encounter with the Filipinos on 4 February 1899. The letter corroborated Private William Grayson's account. Most of the historical accounts had used the testimony of Private Grayson to present the start of the Philippine-American War. While the official report of the government blamed the Filipinos, the letter of Private Thompson and the testimony of Private Grayson attested that their group fired the first shot.

Dear Parents,

I will write a few lines to you to let you know that I am well after the fight we had last Saturday night, and all Sunday and Monday afternoon. I tell you we had a hot time fighting those black insurgents. But, we made them run just like jackrabbits. Then shot them as fast as we could. Our guns were so hot that we burned our fingers on them. Today we have the insurgents clear back to the mountains. How many we have killed of them I don't know, but they say from 5 to 10 thousand of them. Out of Co M we had 1 man killed. His name is Guy Livingstone of Pallesmouth, Nebraska. We had 3 wounded, but not bad. Our company made a charge Sunday morning just as it was getting light, on bamboo thicket which was full of insurgents. Next day they found 80 insurgents killed there. I can tell you that Cornie Egan of St. Edwards got killed Sunday morning. Now I will tell you what time the fight started. On outpost Number 2 and Post 2, there is where the first shot was fired by a Nebraskan boy of Co. D. He shot and killed an insurgent lieutenant who was coming up the road with some other insurgents. They wouldn't halt when the guard called to them to, so he had to shoot them. Then you ought to have heard the bugles blow the call to arms. And the insurgents started to shoot as fast as they could all around us. It was then 9 o'clock Saturday evening. Kept the fight up for about 2 hours. Then it stopped, but to begin again at 3 o'clock Sunday morning and kept it going all day until 3 o'clock in the afternoon. When we had made the insurgent's retreat, it was 11 o'clock. We had to drive them out of a blockhouse and of the bridge. We done by 11 o'clock. Then it went along all right. The insurgents retreated as fast they could back about 2 miles. There we stopped for a rest in the

buildings that they just left. Then we got a little piece of bread to eat. We had not anything to eat since Saturday night. We were tired and sleepy. Some of us lay down to sleep right on the ground with our heads on our haversacks, which had a few bullets in them yet. The Tennessee's one battalion of them came after us and they started after the insurgents then. And 6 insurgents jumped out of the road and held up their hands, and a white flag. But the Tennessee's just shot them before they could say a word. We got a lot of prisoners. All day Monday our company had to bury the dead insurgents around block house no. 7 we buried over 20 of them – 3 or 4 in each grave. I guess you have read all about the war in the papers before you get this letter so you know how many we have killed. I have not got much time to write now. I have been up all the time since Saturday morning until Tuesday night was the first night that I slept all night without getting up and going around on guard. I look so dirty and tired that if you could see me you wouldn't know me. All the boys look alike. We ain't had time to wash for 2 days and 3 nights in which time we was in fight. Well I will tell you about it when I come home. Well I got a chance to shoot at a Filipino., if I didn't get a shot at a Spaniard. One thing I don't know that is how many I shot and killed. Well that is all. I am well. Good bye.

My best regards to all of you,

Henry

145

Correspondences relating to the War with Spain and Conditions Growing out of the same, Including the Insurrection in the Philippine Islands and the China Relief Expedition Between the Adjutant-General of the Army and Military Commanders in the United States, Cuba, Porto Rico, China, and the Philippine Islands, from April 15, 1898 to July 30, 1902. Washington: Government Printing Office, 1902, page 894.

This is a compilation of official documents pertaining to the military affairs of the United States during the Spanish-American, Philippine-American Wars and military operations in China. It includes exchanges of correspondences between the Adjutant-General of the Army (Major General Henry C. Corbin) and the Military Commanders in Cuba, Porto Rico, China and the Philippines during the course of the said wars. It also included some of the related responses and instructions from the Secretary of War and the President of the United States. The Americans belittled the Philippine incident as an insurrection, hence the title of the compilation. However, the Filipinos considered it as a war. The Anti-Imperialists would call it a war of criminal aggression. Some of the military documents included in this compilation are incident reports during the Philippine-American War, such as the encounter between the American and Filipino forces on the night of 4 February 1899. The reports of Philippine Military Governor Elwell Otis to the Adjutant-General as well as that of Secretary Elihu Root to the President were both brief. It is apparent in the letter of Governor Elwell Otis dated 5 February 1899 that he blamed the Filipinos as instigators of the war. Hence, since his report was what the United States Army Adjutant-General received, this report in turn became the basis of Secretary of War Elihu Root's report to President William McKinley. These two reports, however, are contradictory to the

account of Private William Grayson and the letter of Private Henry Thompson.

General Otis' incident report to the Adjutant-General in Washington dated 5 February 1899, saying that the insurgents attacked the Americans.

Insurgents in large force opened attack on our outer lines at 8:45 last evening. Renewed attack several times during night. At 4 o'clock this morning entire line engaged. All attacked repulsed. At daybreak advanced against insurgents and have driven them beyond the lines they formerly occupied, capturing several villages and their defense works. Insurgents loss in dead and wounded large. Our own casualties thus far estimated at 175, very fatal few. We are still driving enemy and think we shall punish them severely. Troops enthusiastic and acting fearlessly. Navy did splendid execution on flanks of enemy. City held in check and absolute quiet prevails. Believe that insurgent army attacked contrary wishes of their government. Insurgents have secured good many Mauser rifles, a few field pieces, and quick firing guns, with ammunition, during last month.

The official report that reached the President of the United States, written by Secretary of War Elihu Root stated that

146

On the night of February 4th, two days before the U.S. Senate approved the treaty, an army of Tagalogs, a tribe inhabiting the central part of Luzon, under the leadership of Aguinaldo, a Chinese half-breed, attacked, in vastly superior numbers, our little army in the possession of Manila, and after a desperate and bloody fight was repulsed in every direction.

147

Liberty Poems. James West Company, 1900, pp13-15; 63-64

In June 1900, The James West Company of Boston had published a book entitled *Liberty Poems*. It was a collection of poems written by notable anti-imperialists such as William Lloyd Garrison, Ernest Crosby, William Vaughn Moody, James Dooling, Clarence Hawkes, W. A. Croffut and others. Some were published in the Anti-Imperialist League newspapers such as Boston Evening Transcript, Sunday Republican, Springfield Republican. Inscribed on the cover of the book was "inspired by the crisis of 1898-1900" and was "made for the New England Anti-Imperialist League," through the efforts of the "supporters of the cause of freedom." What was noticeable in the poems were some of the words used by the soldiers in their letters. Included in the rhetoric of the writers were words like "jack-rabbit," "goo-goos," "Injun," "nigger" in referring to the Filipinos and orders like "take no prisoners," and "spare no one" and some soldiers terms like "war is hell," "war is fun." In addition, the anti-imperialists wrote about the experiences of the

soldiers in the field as narrated by the soldiers to their loved ones. One particular entry was Ernest Crosby's *The Pirate Flag*, which talks about the soldiers accounts about the war as fun, about the looting, about the burning of villages, and about the manslaughter. Crosby wrote about the orders of officers, who despite the waging of white flag of the revolutionary forces, they still killed them because of the "no prisoners" policy during the war. Crosby also alluded to the looting and the plunder that the soldiers, whom he called as "Blue-jackets and marines" in the Philippines. In one stanza, Crosby parodied the men who did the lootings and the killings mistaking them as pirates where in reality, "they were Dewey's men."

The Pirate's Flag

By Ernest Crosby

And then around me fore and aft
The guns began to roar,
And flames sprang up and soon enwrapped
A village on the shore.
I took my glass, and clearly saw
Women and children run,
While soldiers in the palms behind
Were potting them for fun.

148

Far to the left some dusky men
Fought bravely on a knoll;
But, overcome at last, they raised
A white rag on a pole.
Yet still the soldiers shot them down;
And I could almost hear
Their laughter as they seemed to shout,
"No prisoners wanted here!"

Then, when the last defender fell,
The men rushed in with glee;

And from each house they came with loads
Of plunder, sad to see.

And soon we sent a boat ashore,
Blue-jackets and marines,
To get our share of loot and swag,
And spoil the Philippines.

I turned and asked a sailor lad,
For now they stood at ease,
What pirates we might chance to be
Who plagued these summer seas.
“Oh, we’re no pirates,” he replied.
Don’t ask me that again.
This is a ship of Uncle Sam,
And we are Dewey’s men.”

“But how is that?” I said once more.
“Where are your stripes and stars?
And does that inky flag up there

149

Belong to honest tars?”
“To tell the truth, it’s rather queer,”
Replied embarrassed Jack.
“But something in the climate here
Has turned Old Glory black.

The work of Francis Ellingwood Abbot entitled “Old Glory” – “New Shame,” was more intense in accusing the American government of “filthing the flag with mud” due to its imperialistic desire.

“Old Glory”, - “New Shame”

By Francis Ellingwood Abbot

Are we wild wolves, then,

Gorged in our den?

Look to your flag, O Freedom’s men!

Tis filthy with mud,

Soaked with innocent blood,

Loathed of the free and abhorred of God.

Shame on this lust

For the golden dust,

For “commerce” and “markets” in which fools trust!

Shame on this wars

Of Plutus and Mars

Stripes and Dollars, not Stripes and Stars!

Drunken and gory,

Damn not the proud story

That shines in each stripe and each star of “Old Glory”!

The great Declaration

150

That made us a NATION-

‘Tis hissed but by vipers of this generation.

Shall cant, murder, greed,

Blacken Freedom’s bright creed?

Look to it, men of Freedom’s breed!

Wash clean your aim,

Wash your smirched name,

Wash from “Old Glory” the foul “New Shame”!